

Week 11: DNA

BIG IDEA

Halfway through the science unit, pause and take stock: how are your relationships and question-welcoming culture doing, and how are students actually tracking? Don't be afraid to slow down and revisit concepts, and lean on the provided misconceptions and simple examples, like Sean's book analogy for DNA.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- Take a step back this week and analyze your relationships: is the culture of welcome questions, honesty, and developing faith actually growing?
- Ask how new students are assimilating and whether relationships are furthering and getting better since the beginning.
- Honestly assess how students are tracking; some may nod along without getting it, some may be fired up and digging, and everywhere in between.
- Don't be afraid to slow down, pull back, and revisit concepts; don't move forward until you're certain your students are ready.
- The provided misconceptions are a clear window into the underlying narrative students are actually reading in their school textbooks.
- Use the right examples to simplify difficult concepts; the best is Sean's use of simply describing a book to help us understand DNA.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How are your relationships with students going, and do they feel safe being honest with you and one another?
2. Where are your students on the spectrum: nodding without understanding, fired up and asking great questions, or in between?
3. Which concepts from this unit might you need to slow down and revisit before moving forward?
4. What simple examples, like describing a book to explain DNA, could you use to simplify difficult concepts?

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LEADER VIDEO — FULL TRANSCRIPT

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Halfway through the science unit

0:05 So here we are, about halfway through the science unit. I want to stop for a minute and get an idea of how you guys are doing. I want you to take a minute and think about a couple of things. One, how are your relationships doing? We've talked since the beginning about forming good relationships and creating a culture where questions are welcome, where students are being honest with you and with one another, and where their faith is developing. So take a step back, take some time this week, and analyze how that's going. Are your relationships furthering? Are they getting better? Are new students coming in? How are they assimilating? Those types of things.

How students are tracking

0:46 The second thing is, how are students tracking? Now let's be honest: this is not easy. So ask yourself, and maybe even ask some of your students, how are they tracking? Is it all making sense, or do they just kind of nod their heads like they get it, but in the back of their minds they're going, I don't get it? Or are they super fired up, digging for more and asking great questions? Or are you everywhere in between? It's very possible. It could be all over the spectrum.

1:18 But take a second, stop, and think about where your students are, which leads to asking yourself: do I need to slow it down? Do I need to adapt things a little bit? Don't be afraid to pull back and revisit some concepts. Make sure there's understanding. Go back and ask some questions, and figure out and make sure that your students are exactly where you need them to be so that you can move forward successfully. Don't move forward until you are certain that your students are ready to do so.

Two things to keep in mind

1:53 As you and your students are navigating some of these difficult waters, I want you to keep in mind two really important things. The first is the misconceptions that we've provided. These misconceptions are a clear window into the world of what your students are actually being taught. Now, they may not be taught these exact quotes or reading these exact things, but the stuff that we're quoting, the stuff that we're citing, is the underlying narrative that your students are reading about in textbooks in school.

Examples that simplify

2:24 The second thing is the examples that you use. It's so important, if you can, to use the right kind of examples to simplify some of these difficult concepts and make them a little bit easier to understand. And the best example really is Sean's use of simply describing a book to help us understand DNA.